RISE OF THE SOUTHERN STAR

Even as Big B, Shah Rukh Khan and Deepika Padukone remain the leading lights of Bollywood, South Indian stars are making inroads and changing the game—fast

By **SUHANI SINGH**



In sci-fi spectacle ***Kalki 2898 AD*, Amitabh Bachchan's last release dating back to April 2024,** he played Ashvatthama aka the immortal one. That status appears to hold its ground even among respondents of INDIA TODAY's Mood of the Nation poll, who seem to believe that mere hosting duties on *Kaun Banega Crorepati* are enough for the 82-year-old legend to give his decades-younger peers a run for their money.

Allu Arjun remains the sole representative from the South in the top five. But the story among actresses is entirely different. In a first, not one but three leading ladies from the region ranked high: Sai Pallavi, Rashmika Mandanna and Nayanthara. Pallavi

36 PER CENT

Share of respondents in West India whose favourite hero is Amitabh Bachchan, the highest among all regions

Q. WHO IS THE NO. 1 HERO IN THE COUNTRY?



2 **SALMAN KHAN** 9.6 [8.8]



4 **AKSHAY KUMAR** 8.1 [8.4]



5 **ALLU ARJUN** 3.4 [8.9]

1 **AMITABH BACHCHAN** 23.2 [24]

2 **SHAH RUKH KHAN** 9.6 [14]



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All figures in %; rest, others; Aug. '25 figures in bold, Feb. '25 in [ ]